Ahmad Shah Massoud, a trusted aide of Burhanuddin Rabbani and key figure of the Jamaat-e-Islami, fought against the Soviets and the Afghan forces. Both were jewels in our crown despite being poles opposite.'

After a pause, Reddy added: 'Massoud was the only warrior in Afghanistan, all the others were warlords.'

The Beginning of the Afghan Rendezvous

A lot has been written about the exploits of the spies of the US's Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) and Pakistan's Inter-Service Intelligence (ISI) inside Afghanistan at the time the USSR occupied the troubled mountain country. But the R&AW also had its spies in Afghanistan, working to ensure India's security in a situation where the USA was frantically arming Pakistan with cash and sophisticated weaponry to stave off Soviet influence in the region and Pakistan was using much of those USA-provided resources to arm terrorist groups out to harm India.

But the R&AW had seen the threats emanating from Afghanistan months before the Soviet intervention in 1979 and it had duly stepped up its intelligence gathering apparatus in the region. The Indian agency needed allies to counter the unlikely partnership of the mujahideen and the ISI and ensure India's interests were not trampled in the war for control over Afghanistan. The ISI has always been an enemy and its partnership with the CIA had triggered serious concerns in the Indian establishment. The Pakistani agency harbored an abiding resentment of the R&AW, which it blamed for dividing Pakistan with the creation of Bangladesh in 19 71 and also for interference in Balochistan. With the increasing interest of the Soviets, the Pakistanis and the Americans in Afghanistan, the